

In the intervening two-plus years, I'm sure that both VirtualBox and VMware have seen changes. But by this time I was so comfortable using VMware Player, that it was an easy choice for the next exercise.

The fourth time: Linux/Linux/MS Windows

Around Christmas I learnt that one of the members of our group, Iain, was leaving. Although I enjoyed working with him, it was a stroke of luck for me. I was suddenly the master of two PCs. Finally, I could prepare my 'ideal platform' without constraint.

I won't discuss the details. In brief, I installed CentOS 5.7 from CDs. After customising to my taste, I downloaded and installed VMware-Player-3.1.5. For my XP box, I downloaded VMware vCenter Converter Standalone Client. It's very clever; it packs up the entire XP environment, and creates a VM of the machine, all of which lives in a single directory.

Before I copied the VM, I tweaked a few things. Instead of running eight CPUs, I reduced it to two. I reduced the original 4 GB to 1 GB. I wasn't sure how many CPUs VMware would actually allocate to XP as a VM. I copied this VM of my old machine to my new CentOS. I started VMware and pointed it to the new VM. It thought long and hard, and finally agreed to acknowledge it as one of its own.

XP was noticeably slow (which I cannot say for CentOS running under XP).

I downloaded Fedora 16 from <http://www.thoughtpolice.co.uk/vmware/#fedora16> and started it under VMware. Soon, I had it customised to how I like things.

I set up NFS server on the CentOS host, and NFS client on the Fedora guest, so that I could share files between the two environments. For me, it's a lot simpler and more familiar than setting up VMware Tools.

Evaluation

All the reasons for running CentOS that I listed in the previous 'Evaluation' apply here: compatibility, stability and reliability. Installing VMware Player under Linux was very easy. Obtaining and launching VMs was straightforward.

There was a major performance issue when I ran the XP VM. Sometimes it was a little slow but acceptable. At other times, it impacted performance so badly that the whole machine was unusable. It may have been a mistake packaging my original machine as a VM. There are so many places where I might have got things wrong. The original machine was 4 GB and 8 CPUs and, of course, XP, being the host, had all of it. I only allocated 1 GB and 2 CPUs to XP as a VM. I had the impression that the problem was the virus scanner—whenever it decided to do a full scan of the disk. After a while, I stopped using the XP VM. That was the main reason I had installed Fedora.

The performance of Fedora (and CentOS while running Fedora) has been nothing short of brilliant. In daily use, I don't use Fedora's GUI at all. If I want to run on the Fedora

VM, I SSH in. Once there, I set my DISPLAY variable to point back to the CentOS host. I can then run any application on the Fedora VM and it will display on my desktop, seamlessly and effortlessly. It really doesn't feel like a host and a guest, more like two networked machines.

I have no qualms about installing experimental software in the VM, because if it behaves badly, I can uninstall it at leisure, while I continue using the host CentOS for other activities. If an application runs acceptably for a period of time, and it seems appropriate, I migrate it to the host CentOS. If something I install completely breaks the VM, I can revert to an earlier backup or snapshot.

There are several applications that I run in the Fedora guest, which I have no intention of migrating: LibreOffice for Word documents and Excel spreadsheets; Pidgin for IMS (instead of Lync); Dillo, a lightweight browser; and Google Chrome, a heavy browser.

I could think about running some Linux equivalent of Outlook, but most of the time, the Web interface to Outlook is adequate. I actually prefer NMH for mail, and I have installed some software that lets me download mail from Exchange Server to my CentOS machine. I use Exchange Server as a huge backup of all my mail. I use the Web interface as a 'heads up' to see what mail is in my inbox, and I use NMH for reading and responding.

I've been running like this for about three months. At first, I kept turning on the old machine because some functionality was missing, but these days, I rarely need it. I'm interoperating almost seamlessly with users who have Macs, XP or Windows 7 on their desk.

But the big win for me is that my environment is extremely comfortable when I do my common daily tasks. As I said at the beginning: I spend most of my day wrangling Linux and Solaris servers. 

References

- [1] <http://linuxgazette.net/183/grebler1.html>
- [2] <http://www.linuxforu.com/2012/05/virtualisation-faceoff-qemu-virtualbox-vmware-player-parallels-workstation/>

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The author has spent his days working with computers, mostly for computer manufacturers or software developers. His early computer experience includes relics such as punch cards, paper tape and mag tape. His darkest secret is that he has been paid to do the sorts of things he would have paid money to be allowed to do. Just don't tell any of his employers. He has used Linux as his personal home desktop since the family got its first PC in 1996. Back then, when the family shared the one PC, it was a dual-boot Windows/ Slackware set-up. Now that each member has his/her own computer, Henry somehow survives in a purely Linux world. He lives in a suburb of Melbourne, Australia.